

Chapter 1

Mass culture and popular culture

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THE SOCIAL SIGNIFICANCE OF popular culture in the modern era can be charted by the way it has been identified with mass culture. The coming of the mass media and the increasing commercialisation of culture and leisure gave rise to issues, interests and debates which are still with us today. The growth of the idea of mass culture, very evident from the 1920s and 1930s onwards, is one of the historical sources of the themes and perspectives on popular culture which this book discusses.

This is not to say that the debate over mass culture represents something totally new. Lowenthal (1957), for example, has traced some of its central arguments back to the writings of Pascal and Montaigne in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, and linked their emergence to the rise of a market economy. Others argue they have always been with us, pointing to the 'bread and circuses' function of popular culture in the Roman empire. More convincingly, Burke suggests that the modern idea of popular culture is associated

with the development of national consciousness in the late eighteenth century, and results from the attempt by intellectuals to turn popular culture into national culture. The distinction, for example, between popular culture and 'high' or 'learned' culture is to be found in this period in the writings of the German poet Herder (Burke 1978:8).

The contrasting implications associated with the history of the idea of popular culture are clearly noted by Williams (1976). Referring to a 'shift in perspective' between the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, he notes that 'popular' meant 'being seen from the point of view of the people rather than from those seeking favour or power over them'. However, 'the earlier sense had not died.' This meant that 'popular culture was not identified by the people but by others.' It also 'carries two older senses: inferior kinds of work (cf. popular literature, popular press as distinguished from quality press); and work deliberately setting out to win favour (popular journalism as distinguished from democratic journalism, or popular entertainment); as well as the more modern sense of well liked by many people'. Last, 'the recent sense of popular culture as the culture actually made by people for themselves is different from all these; it is often displaced to the past as folk culture but it is also an important modern emphasis' (Williams 1976:199).

The development of the idea of popular culture is linked to arguments about meaning and interpretation which predate but become strikingly evident in the debates over mass culture. In particular, three related themes can be found in the work referred to above which, while not being exhaustive, have been central to theories of popular culture ever since.¹ The first concerns what or who determines popular culture. Where does popular culture come from? Does it emerge from the people themselves as an autonomous expression of their interests and modes of experience, or is it imposed from above by those in positions of power as a type of social control? Does popular culture rise up from the people 'below', or does it sink down from elites 'on high', or is it rather a question of

an interaction between the two? The second theme concerns the influence of commercialisation and industrialisation upon popular culture. Does the emergence of culture in commodity forms mean that criteria of profitability and marketability take precedence over quality, artistry, integrity and intellectual challenge? Or does the increasingly universal market for popular culture ensure that it is truly popular because it makes available commodities people actually want? What wins out when popular culture is manufactured industrially and sold according to the criteria of marketability and profitability—commerce or quality? The third theme concerns the ideological role of popular culture. Is popular culture there to indoctrinate the people, to get them to accept and adhere to ideas and values which ensure the continued dominance of those in more privileged positions who thus exercise power over them? Or is it about rebellion and opposition to the prevailing social order? Does it express, in however an imperceptible, subtle and rudimentary manner, resistance to those in power, and the subversion of dominant ways of thinking and acting?

These are issues which are still very much alive in the study of popular culture today, but they (as well as others) received systematic and substantial attention in the debates about mass culture which started to gather pace from the 1920s onwards.² The 1920s and 1930s are significant turning points in the study and evaluation of popular culture. The coming of cinema and radio, the mass production and consumption of culture, the rise of fascism and the maturing of liberal democracies in certain western societies, all played their part in setting the agendas of these debates.³

The very fact that culture came to be almost infinitely reproducible due to the development of techniques of industrial production posed considerable problems for traditional ideas about the role of culture and art in society (Benjamin:1973). Cultural products such as films were not, of course, mass produced in the same way as motor cars. However, the introduction of mass production techniques into

the making of films, and the mass consumption afforded by cinemas, meant they could be regarded as commercial products.⁴ For a number of the writers we shall look at in this chapter, this meant that cultural products, such as cinema, could not be authentic and genuine works of art. Equally, they could not be 'folk' culture because they no longer came from the 'people', and therefore could not reflect or satisfy their experiences and interests.

Apart from the popular press, cinema and radio were arguably the first archetypically modern mass media to emerge. They fuelled fears about the commercialisation of culture, and raised concerns about the potential they conferred upon political regimes (particularly but not exclusively fascist ones) for mass propaganda. The existence of highly efficient means of reaching large numbers of people within societies with centralised, totalitarian political systems was seen by many as another way, along with coercion, of further entrenching such systems and suppressing democratic alternatives. Mass media such as radio and film transmitted and inculcated the official ideology of the fascist state because they could be controlled centrally and broadcast to the population at large. The absence of countervailing political organisations in totalitarian societies just added to the efficiency of this equation: mass media equalled mass propaganda equalled mass repression. This potential was also marked by the deliberate and conscious attempt by the Nazi party in Germany in the 1930s to establish official Nazi ideology in all areas of culture and art, and eradicate alternative political and aesthetic ideologies. The aim was to enlist the help of intellectuals, writers, novelists, poets, painters, sculptors, musicians, academicians, architects, etc., in ensuring that Nazi ideology prevailed as Nazi aesthetics. Totalitarian societies, along with liberal democracies, have been viewed as types of mass society. The concept of mass society has formed one important perspective on the role of mass media and mass culture in modern capitalist societies. It has been the fears and anxieties of intellectuals, in societies

such as Britain and America, about the rise of what they have seen as a mass society and a mass culture which have served to organise and inform the debates about these developments.⁵

Mass culture and mass society

Although what follows may look something like an identikit picture which nobody can be or wants to be identified with, I shall single out the main points advanced by mass society theory. This should illustrate its relevance to debates about the nature of popular culture as mass culture.⁶

The major claim of mass society theory refers to the disruptive consequences of industrialisation and urbanisation. The rise of large-scale and mechanised industrial production, and the growth of massive and densely populated cities, are argued to have destabilised and then eroded the societies and values which previously held people together. These radical changes included the eradication of agrarian work tied to the land, the destruction of the tightly knit village community, the decline of religion and the secularisation of societies; and they have been associated with the growth of scientific knowledge, the spread of mechanised, monotonous and alienating factory work, the development of large anomic cities populated by anonymous crowds, and the relative absence of moral integration. These processes are thought to lie behind the emergence of a mass society and mass culture.

The theory argues that industrialisation and urbanisation serve to create what is called 'atomisation'. This defines precisely what is meant by a mass society. A mass society consists of people who can only relate to each other like atoms in a physical or chemical compound. Mass society consists of atomised people, people who lack any meaningful or morally coherent relationships with each other. These people are clearly not conceived of purely and simply as isolated atoms, but the links between them are said to be purely contractual, distant and sporadic rather than close, communal and well integrated. In a mass society, the individual is left more and

more to his or her own devices, has fewer and fewer communities or institutions in which to find identity or values by which to live, and has less and less idea of the morally appropriate ways to live.

People find themselves in this situation as 'atomised individuals' because industrialisation and urbanisation lead to the decline of mediating social organisations. These are organisations, such as the village, the family and the church, which once provided a sense of psychological identity, social conduct and moral certainty for the individual. In contrast, their modern counterparts, such as the city or science, do not work in the same way; they cannot foster identity, define conduct and fashion morality. According to the theory, people in a mass society are atomised both socially and morally. Not only are the contacts between people purely formal and contractual, but they lack any deeper sense of moral integrity since moral order declines in a mass society. The point here is that if no appropriate framework of moral order is forthcoming, if people do not have a secure sense of moral value, then a spurious and ineffectual order will emerge instead, and people will turn to surrogate and fake moralities. This will thereby aggravate rather than resolve the moral crisis of mass society. Mass culture plays a part here in that it is seen as one of the major sources of a surrogate and ineffective morality. Without appropriate mediatory organisations, individuals are vulnerable to manipulation and exploitation by core institutions such as the mass media and popular culture. There is no moral order to prevent this happening. Religious certainties and communal verities give way to the amoral immediacy of rational individualism and secular anomie associated with the rise of mass consumption and mass culture, the moral placebos of a mass society.

Though this claim is not integral to every version of the theory, mass culture theorists have suggested that democracy and education can be harmful developments in that they may contribute to the pathological condition of mass society. This point is particularly relevant to the debate about

Americanisation which will be discussed more fully later in this chapter. Fears about Americanisation in the nineteenth century concerned the effects of democracy and education in a number of areas: breaking down traditional hierarchies of class and taste; allowing the 'mass' or the 'mob' to be the majority in the polity and culture, and to thus determine political decisions and lower cultural standards; supposedly realising the tyranny of the ignorant majority over the cultivation of minority taste; and ensuring the reduction of all questions of moment to the lowest common denominator.

From this point of view, democracy means that everyone is entitled to full political citizenship, and that, potentially, everyone's general cultural preferences are as valuable and as worthy of being respected and fulfilled as those of traditional elites. Furthermore, as part of this process of democratisation, education means that the capacity to engage more fully in cultural activities—the abilities to read, write, discriminate, demand, know, understand—becomes more accessible, formally at least, to more and more people. Just as the mass or the population at large began to be regarded as the main influence upon government and political decisions because of the extension of political citizenship rights, so the expansion of this trend in culture, combined with the effects of universal elementary education, is seen to result in the popular determination of the culture of mass societies.

This has not, however, always been seen in a favourable light. On the contrary, it is argued that because the masses lack taste and discrimination, culture is thereby debased and trivialised. If the tastes of the masses are to be satisfied, then everything has to be reduced to the lowest common denominator of the average or the mass. The people have to have a culture of their own, one which reflects their status and judgement as a mass. Democracy and education entail the breakdown of cultural distinctions between art and folk culture on the one hand, and mass culture on the other, in the same way that industrialisation and urbanisation entail the breakdown of traditions of community and morality. These

fears continued well into the twentieth century, and could be argued to be present, in differing guises, at subsequent points of major cultural change.

However, mass society theory does not necessarily have a democratic theory of power, and if it does it does not think that it is a good thing. It tends to argue that the processes it describes invest power in the central institutions of the society, the commercial industries, the state and the mass media. Mass society theory is one attempt to understand the rise of mass propaganda, the potential for elites to use the mass media to more systematically and pervasively cajole, persuade, manipulate and exploit the people than had previously been possible. Those who control the institutions of power pander to the tastes of the mass in order to control them. If traditional communal and moral frameworks, and respected hierarchies of class and status, are breaking down, and there are no institutions left to mediate the relationships between the atomised individual and the centralised powers of mass society, the individual is open to the persuasive, manipulative and coercive force exercised by the combined or separate power of capitalism, the state and the mass media. Alternatively, if a specific variant of the theory complains about the rise of political and cultural democracy because they appear to work, and uses elitist criteria of taste and discrimination to criticise mass culture, then it is the power of the mass, and not its lack, which is emphasised. But again it is not welcomed or celebrated.

Before going on to look directly at the theory of mass culture an important definition needs to be clarified. This concerns the differences between elite culture or art, popular or folk culture, and mass culture, and arises because theories of mass society and mass culture usually rely upon a clear division between the past and the present. The division is normally taken to refer to a process of social change from a 'better' or preferable past to a degenerating and uninviting present and future. The pre-mass society is viewed as a communal and organic whole in which people accept and

abide by a shared and agreed-upon set of values which effectively regulate their integration into the community, and which recognise hierarchy and difference. There is a place for art, the culture of elites, and a place for a genuinely popular folk culture which arises from the grass roots, is self-created and autonomous, and directly reflects the lives and experiences of the people. This authentically popular folk culture can never aspire to be art, but its distinctiveness is accepted and respected. With industrialisation and urbanisation this situation changes. Community and morality break down, and individuals become isolated, alienated and anomic, caught up in increasingly financial and contractual social relationships. They are absorbed into an increasingly anonymous mass, manipulated by their only source of a surrogate community and morality, the mass media. In this society, mass culture suppresses folk culture and undermines the integrity of art.

To indicate the relevance of this to the themes of this chapter we can quote a leading theorist of mass culture:

Folk art grew from below. It was a spontaneous, autochthonous expression of the people, shaped by themselves, pretty much without the benefit of High Culture, to suit their own needs. Mass Culture is imposed from above. It is fabricated by technicians hired by businessmen; its audiences are passive consumers, their participation limited to the choice between buying and not buying.... Folk Art was the people's own institution, their private little garden walled off from the great formal park of their master's High Culture. But Mass Culture breaks down the wall, integrating the masses into a debased form of High Culture and thus becoming an instrument of political domination.

(MacDonald 1957:60)⁷

This statement summarises concisely how this perspective defines the differences between elite, folk and mass culture. We now have to consider more fully the implications of these differences, and the meaning of the idea of mass culture.

The mass culture debate

Put simply, we can say that mass culture refers to popular culture which is produced by the industrial techniques of mass production, and marketed for profit to a mass public of consumers.⁸ It is commercial culture, mass produced for a mass market. Its growth means there is less room for any culture which cannot make money, and which cannot be mass produced for a mass market, such as art and folk culture. This also indicates how mass culture theory can be understood as a response to the industrialisation and commercialisation of popular culture on a grand scale which began to gather momentum in the 1920s and 1930s. The terms of the theory and its implications need to be made clear before we show how, in this country, it has been bound up with the debate about Americanisation. This will be followed by a critical examination of its claims.

First, we can note that industrialisation and urbanisation gave rise to an atomised and anonymous mass ripe for manipulation, a mass market for the mass media best catered for by mass culture. Both mass production industries and mass markets encouraged the spread of mass culture. For this approach, the main determinant of mass culture is the profit its production and marketing can make from its potential mass market. If culture can't make money then it is unlikely to be produced. The theory also stresses the effects of the mass production of mass culture. The use of mass production techniques, along with the commercial need to make a profit, are seen to have a harmful and corrupting influence on the culture produced in mass, industrial societies. It is argued that aspects of mass production such as the assembly line, a highly specialised division of labour, the strict separation of different stages of production, and output quotas (some of which could be said to have characterised the Hollywood studio system between the 1920s and the 1950s) stamp mass culture with the features associated with the products of mass production industries.

From this point of view, there is no real difference between material and cultural products, between, say, the production of cars and the production of films. The standardised, formulaic and repetitive products of mass culture are the result of the manufacture of cultural commodities by means of routine, specialised, assembly-line types of production. Art, for example, cannot be produced in this way. The alleged aesthetic complexity, creativity, experiments and intellectual challenges of art cannot be achieved by the techniques or conditions which produce mass culture. Instead, art depends upon the inspired genius of the individual artist working outside the constraints of the commercial market, and without the tried and tested formulas and standard techniques of mass culture. Equally, folk culture has to be produced by an integrated community which knows what it is doing, and which can thereby guarantee the authenticity of its products.

This argument is associated with a specific idea of the audience for mass culture, the mass public which consumes mass-produced cultural products. This audience is understood to be a mass of passive consumers, susceptible to the manipulative persuasions of the mass media, acquiescent with the appeals to buy mass-produced commodities such as mass culture, supine before the false pleasures of mass consumption, and open to the commercial exploitation which motivates mass culture. The picture is of a mass of people which, almost without thinking or reflecting, accepts mass culture and mass consumption. The emergence of mass society and mass culture means it lacks the intellectual and moral resources to do otherwise. It cannot think of alternatives since its cultural universe is reduced to one common mass. Art lies beyond its aspirations, and it has already lost its folk culture. The nature of this audience therefore means that culture can be profitably mass produced.

The bland and standardised formulas of mass culture are developed to sell things to this mass consuming public because they can be made to appeal to everyone since everyone, every atomised person, is open to manipulation.

Also, mass cultural products can be made in large numbers by mass production industries. There is thus no point in making demands upon or challenging this audience in the way that art might do, or drawing it into genuine and authentic forms of communal participation as folk culture might do, since their conditions can no longer be sustained. Instead, the mass audience is there to have its emotions and sensibilities manipulated, to have its needs and desires distorted and thwarted, to have its hopes and aspirations exploited for the sake of consumption, by the meretricious sentiments, the surrogate fantasies, the false dreams of mass culture. In effect, mass society delivers up people to mass exploitation by mass culture.

This idea of the audience is quite common to theories of popular culture. According to one of its leading proponents, mass culture theory argues that if 'people are organized...as masses, they lose their human identity and quality...they are related to one another neither as individuals nor as members of communities'. Instead, every individual exists as 'a solitary atom, uniform with and undifferentiated from thousands and millions of other atoms who go to make up "the lonely crowd" as David Reisman well calls American society.' By contrast, 'a folk or a people... is a community, i.e., a group of individuals linked to each other by common interests, work, traditions, values, and sentiments' (MacDonald 1957:69; cf. Frith 1983:252).

From this point of view, mass culture is a standardised, formulaic, repetitive and superficial culture, one which celebrates trivial, sentimental, immediate and false pleasures at the expense of serious, intellectual, time-honoured and authentic values. MacDonald laments what he calls the 'spreading ooze of Mass Culture', and argues 'it is a debased, trivial culture that voids both the deep realities (sex, death, failure, tragedy) and also the simple, spontaneous pleasures'. This occurs because 'the realities would be too real and the pleasures too lively' to encourage 'a narcotized acceptance of Mass Culture and of the commodities it sells as a substitute

for the unsettling and unpredictable (hence unstable) joy, tragedy, wit, change, originality and beauty of real life.' The result is that 'the masses, debauched by several generations of this sort of thing, in turn come to demand trivial and comfortable cultural products' (MacDonald 1957:72-73).

Mass culture is therefore a culture which lacks intellectual challenge and stimulation, providing instead the undemanding ease of fantasy and escapism. It is a culture which discourages the effort of thinking and creates its own emotional and sentimental responses. It does not demand that its audience thinks for itself, works out its own responses, and entertains responses which are intellectual and critical. In this sense, it begins to define social reality for the mass public. It therefore tends to simplify the real world and gloss over its problems. If these problems are recognised, it usually treats them superficially by presenting glib and false solutions. It equally encourages commercialism and celebrates consumerism, together with the virtues of profit and the market. Also, just as it denies intellectual challenge, it tends to silence other opposing voices because it is a stultifying and pacifying culture.

The rise of mass culture would, on its own, be considered enough of a danger by some of the writers we consider in this chapter. But there is more to the argument than what has been described so far. The eclipse of folk culture could not be resisted by the 'people', but high culture and the role of the traditional intellectual elite are equally at risk. This is the core of many of the anxieties, fears and hostilities expressed by this elite about mass culture. Another culture, an elite culture—what might be termed 'art'—has remained in place above the already doomed folk culture being deserted by the masses in favour of mass culture. Nevertheless, the position and security of the high cultural elite, its privileged judgement and arbitration of taste, the voice it has to speak on behalf of those excluded from high culture, have been challenged both by the spread of mass culture and its general trivialisation of all culture, and by the presumed loss among the mass of the

skills and abilities required to appreciate and understand high culture.

For some, like MacDonald, this would not be that much of a problem if the people could keep to their own folk cultural pastimes, and leave art to the elite. For others, however, it served as a warning of just how pernicious the hold of mass culture could be. Writing in the early 1930s in an interesting study of the book market, the English literary and social critic, Q.D.Leavis (1906–1981), expressed her concerns as follows:

It is not perhaps surprising that, in a society of forty three millions so decisively stratified in taste that each stratum is catered for independently by its own novelists and journalists, the lowbrow public should be ignorant of the work and even of the names of the highbrow writers, while to the highbrow public 'Ethel M.Dell' or 'Tarzan' should be convenient symbols, drawn from hearsay rather than first-hand knowledge. But what close at hand is apparently trivial becomes a serious development when we realise that this means nothing less than that the general public—Dr Johnson's common reader—has now not even a glimpse of the living interests of modern literature, is ignorant of its growth and so prevented from developing with it, and that the critical minority to whose sole charge modern literature has now fallen is isolated, disowned by the general public and threatened with extinction. Poetry and criticism are not read by the common reader; the drama, in so far as it ever overlapped literature, is dead, and the novel is the only branch of letters which is now generally supported.

(Leavis 1932:35)⁹

Her study is designed to show how the serious, high-brow novel is next.

According to MacDonald, mass culture is a threat because it is a homogeneous culture which levels down or debases all culture. He argues it 'is a dynamic, revolutionary force,

breaking down the old barriers of class, tradition, taste, and dissolving all cultural distinctions...producing what might be called homogenized culture.' As such, it 'destroys all values, since value judgements imply discrimination.' He therefore concludes that 'mass culture is very, very democratic: it absolutely refuses to discriminate against, or between, anything or anybody' (MacDonald 1957:62).

This argument is clearly similar to those we hear today regarding the postmodern traits of contemporary culture. It also shows, as does Q.D.Leavis's argument, just how the intellectual elite's arbitration of cultural taste is open to the democratising threat posed by mass culture. The real problem sometimes seems to be that mass culture, unlike folk culture, refuses to stay in its place and stick with the masses, but has pretensions beyond its station and merits; it refuses to recognise traditional hierarchies of taste, and the cultural distinctions generated by those at the top. For these theorists, mass culture is a danger because it can undermine the distinctions established between elite and popular culture. It can co-opt, while at the same time debasing and trivialising, what high culture has to offer.

Q.D.Leavis makes this clear in her analysis of the fate of the then modern novel. She notes the effects of the growing taste for mass culture as follows:

The training of the reader who spends his leisure in cinemas, looking through magazines and newspapers, listening to jazz music, does not merely fail to help him, it prevents him from normal development, partly by providing him with a set of habits inimical to mental effort...whereas the eighteenth century and nineteenth century helped the reader, the twentieth century hinders.... This meant...an inability to be bored and a capacity to concentrate, due in part, no doubt, to the fact that there was no competition of amusements provided. Life was not then a series of frivolous stimuli as it now is for the suburban dweller, and there was time for the less

immediate pleasures. The temptation to accept the cheap and easy pleasures offered by the cinema, the circulating library, the magazine, the newspaper, the dance-hall, and the loud-speaker is too much for almost every one. To refrain would be to exercise a severer self-discipline than even the strongest-minded are likely to practise, for only the unusually self-disciplined can fight against their environment and only the unusually self-aware could perceive the necessity of doing so.

(Leavis 1932:224–225)

This conclusion is confirmed for Leavis by the ‘disappearance of poetry from the average man’s reading’, and by the fact that book clubs don’t improve taste but rather standardise it (*ibid.*: 229). Thus, ‘the general reading public of the twentieth century is no longer in touch with the best literature of its own day or of the past.’ This occurs because ‘the idiom that the general public of the twentieth century possesses is not merely crude and puerile; it is made up of phrases and clichés that imply fixed, or rather stereotyped, habits of thinking and feeling at second-hand taken over from the journalist’ (*ibid.*: 235, 255); and, we might add, from other producers of mass culture as well.

The threat posed to high culture by mass culture is given a slightly different slant by MacDonald. He suggests that in the 1920s the mass culture of Hollywood cinema (which was mitigated to a limited extent by avant-garde and folk art) and the high culture of Broadway theatre were clearly and sharply distinguished from each other in terms of production—commercial versus artistic criteria; texts—popular pleasure versus intellectual stimulation; and audience—the masses versus the metropolitan upper class. However, with the arrival of the sound film these distinctions began to break down. He notes that

plays are now produced mainly to sell the movie rights, with many being directly financed by the film companies. The merger has standardised the theatre

expunging both the classical and the experimental...
and...the movies...too have become standardised...they
are better entertainment and worse art

(MacDonald 1957:64–65)

If it is the case that mass culture has threatened to unseat high culture and take over, where does this leave art and the avant-garde? What role if any can they play in the era of mass culture? As with so many who hold to this understanding of popular culture, MacDonald adopts a position of cultural pessimism. For him, 'bad stuff drives out the good, since it is more easily understood and enjoyed' (*ibid.*: p. 61). But he does see the artistic avant-garde having a defensive role to play because it is, by definition, outside the market place, and can maintain artistic standards. It can therefore oppose mass culture. The modernist avant-garde between the late nineteenth century and the 1930s (MacDonald cites Rimbaud, Joyce, Stravinsky and Picasso) tried to preserve an area outside the market and mass culture where 'the serious artist could still function'. In this it was 'remarkably successful', producing the only worthwhile art in this period (*ibid.*: 63).

But for MacDonald it is doubtful whether this intellectual community can sustain itself. His is a cultural pessimism in which the future is truly dark, and in which alternatives are being closed off. It is only the modernist avant-garde which seems to hold out a faint glimmer of hope. There is no sense here of the idea that mass or popular culture may not be the monolithic or homogeneous phenomenon mass culture theory makes it out to be, and that therefore diversity, innovation and opposition may well exist within as well as outside this culture. Also, whether popular culture is in itself a bad thing is something which is not questioned. There are notable similarities in these respects between mass culture theory and the Frankfurt School's analysis of modern culture. However, the Frankfurt School does have a more systematic idea of the role an avant-garde can play as the guardian of truth and values in an age of mass culture.

Indeed, Q.D. Leavis puts forward a somewhat comparable argument in pointing to ways of preventing mass culture from undermining literary standards and destroying the reading public. What she argues is that the cultural rot can only be stopped by the efforts of a committed intellectual elite: 'all that can be done, it must be realised, must take the form of resistance by an armed and conscious minority' (1932:270). The role of this elite, this conscious minority, is two-fold. First, it must carry out research to show just how bad things have become, how far the literary standards and reading capacities of the general public have declined and how restricted a role the serious novel and writer have to play in cultural life. This will equip the elite with the information it needs to carry out its mission to reverse the decline produced by mass culture, rather than enlightening the people directly. The result of this research would not only be books to increase 'general awareness': 'it would also mean the training of a picked few who would go out into the world equipped for the work of forming and organising a conscious minority' (ibid.: 271).

This leads us to the second role of this minority, that of 'educational work in schools and universities' (ibid.). Here the function of the 'conscious minority' is, first, to constitute an elite avant-garde which will substantiate and disseminate its interpretation of the rise of mass culture, and warn the population about, and try to reverse, the decline of serious culture; and, second, to regain its position of authority in education, and hence its position of authority as the ultimate arbiter of cultural and artistic taste and values. For Leavis, 'the possibilities of education specifically directed against such appeals as those made by the journalist, the middleman, the best-seller, the cinema, and advertising, and the other more general influences discussed in this study, are inexhaustible; some education of this kind is an essential part of the training of taste' (ibid.). This minority may be the only hope Leavis holds out for the future, but she does not share MacDonald's ambiguity about the influence that an intellectual avant-garde

can exercise. Her analysis is therefore instructive not only for what it says about what she sees as the debasing effect of mass culture upon literary standards, but also for its political response to this situation which involves a coherent theory of the role of an intellectual and elite avant-garde.

So far this chapter has presented an outline of the theory of mass culture. It has done this by relating it to the theory of mass society with which it shares much in common. It has been shown how the concept of mass culture involves the mass production and consumption of culture, the threatened subversion of folk culture and high culture, and the relationship between cultural pessimism and the role played by an intellectual avant-garde. It has been argued that the concept of mass culture provides a picture of a debased, trivialised, superficial, artificial and standardised culture which saps the strength of folk and high culture, and challenges the intellectual arbitration of cultural taste. This account may be somewhat simplified and exaggerated. It is always open to the charge that it does not do justice to the work of X, the ideas of Y, or the concept Z. While recognising this argument, we can still insist that what has been outlined can be found, in whole or in part, in most accounts of mass culture as popular culture. It could also be argued that nobody thinks in terms of mass culture any more, that we now know how to appreciate popular as well as high culture. However, as we shall see, ideas similar to mass culture can still be found in subsequent theories of popular culture, even though it may not be described and understood in quite the same way.

Mass culture and Americanisation

The theory of mass culture outlined above has also been concerned about the process of Americanisation. The fears and anxieties expressed by critics of mass culture have been equally directed at the threat of Americanisation.¹⁰ The reason for this is that American popular culture is seen to embody all that is wrong with mass culture. Mass culture is thought to

arise from the mass production and consumption of culture. Since it is the capitalist society most closely associated with these processes, it is relatively easy to identify America as the home of mass culture. So much mass culture comes from America that if it is a threat then Americanisation is a threat as well. For domestic critics of mass culture, Americanisation threatens not just aesthetic standards and cultural values, but national culture as well.

It is therefore interesting that intellectual concern in Britain about the harmful effects of American influence can be found in the nineteenth century, before the mass production and consumption of culture began to be fully realised. This is where American populism and the consequences of mass democracy and education become important. Q.D.Leavis, for example, cites Edmund Gosse, writing in 1889, as follows:

One danger which I have long foreseen from the spread of the democratic sentiment, is that of the tradition of literary taste, the canons of literature, being reversed with success by a popular vote. Up to the present time, in all parts of the world, the masses of uneducated or semi-educated persons, who form the vast majority of readers, though they cannot and do not appreciate the classics of their race, have been content to acknowledge their supremacy. Of late there have seemed to me to be certain signs, especially in America, of a revolt of the mob against our literary masters.... If literature is to be judged by a plebiscite, and if the plebs recognise its power, it will certainly by degrees cease to support reputations which give it no pleasure and which it cannot comprehend. The revolution against taste, once begun, will land us in irreparable chaos

(Leavis 1932:190)

The similarity between this kind of argument and the theory of mass culture should be obvious. America is the home of the mass revolt against literary taste, and what is happening there

can happen here if the 'democratic sentiment' is allowed to spread.

It is not that difficult to find early examples of anti-American sentiment. In his book *Culture and Anarchy*, originally published in 1869, the English poet and literary critic Matthew Arnold (1822–1888) wrote: 'in things of the mind, and in culture and totality, America, instead of surpassing us all, falls short.' America here is 'that chosen home of newspapers and politics' (cited in Webster 1988:180). Arnold's fears about Americanisation were part of his concern that democracy should not 'just give power to the masses, but should entail a polity guided and directed by the state and a properly constituted culture.' As such, the latter should involve the 'pursuit of our total perfection by means of getting to know, on all the matters which most concern us, the best which has been thought and said in the world' (Arnold 1932: 6).

It would probably be correct to say that the equation Arnold draws is between Americanisation and mass democracy rather than Americanisation and mass culture. However, as a number of writers have suggested, democratisation and mass culture are not that easily distinguished from each other. Johnson notes, for example, that Arnold feared 'vulgarity, loss of distinction and, above all, that eccentricity of thought which arises when each man, no matter what his training or gifts, may feel that the democratic doctrine of equality allows him to consider his ideas of equal worth with those of his neighbour'. He thus 'used America as a case study to analyse the possible dangers and trends of democracy', and 'thereafter, in English thought America or "Americanization" was often seen as the epitome of what was most dangerous in the development of modern industrial society.' For Arnold Americanisation 'meant two things': 'a tendency towards fragmentariness' [the absence of a powerful central authority be it an aristocracy or the state to guide, educate, establish standards]; 'and an addiction to the banal' [the absence of standards of excellence and the cultural and moral

degeneration of society which could only be halted by a proper cultural and moral education] (Johnson 1979:21; cf. Webster 1988:180–181).

This seems to be a consistent line of argument, although it has obviously undergone subsequent changes in context and content. It is thus worth considering the work of the English literary and social critic F.R. Leavis (1895–1978), who was responding directly to a clearly emergent mass culture. He assumed that Americanisation was an accomplished fact: ‘it is a common-place that we are being Americanised’ (cited in Webster 1988: 180–181; originally published 1933).

Leavis was a critic of mass society and mass culture, and saw America as an embodiment of both of these dangers. As Hebdige has noted with respect to the anxieties expressed about Americanisation in post-1945 British society, one of the main processes which caused concern was the ‘levelling-down’ that Americanisation represented (Hebdige 1988: [chapter 3](#)). This levelling-down, the apparent potential for greater economic, political and cultural equality, appears also to have worried Leavis. He saw mass society as involving mass production and standardisation, generating an almost irrepressible shift to a mass culture dominated by the mass media. This involved the soporific pleasures of a superficial culture, and the exploitation of a rootless and uneducated public, which consequently became indifferent to the standards of great art. Americanisation was thus the nub of the problem for Leavis because American society had the most developed mass culture, and thus represented the future towards which other comparable societies, such as Britain, were heading: ‘American conditions are the conditions of modern civilization, even if the “drift” has gone further on the other side of the Atlantic than on this’ (cited in Johnson 1979: 96).

These fears about Americanisation have not been confined to a backward-looking and elitist conservatism, but can be found on the left as well. In this context an interesting socialist writer on Americanisation is the English novelist Orwell

(1903–1950), who voices many of the concerns of the more traditionally conservative critics. Perhaps something of the flavour of Orwell's stance is captured in the following quote on the 'decline of the English murder':

it is significant that the most talked of English murder of recent years should have been committed by an American and an English girl who had become partly Americanized. But it is difficult to believe that this case will be so long remembered as the old domestic poisoning dramas, product of a stable society where the all-prevailing hypocrisy did at least ensure that crimes as serious as murder should have strong emotions behind them.

(Orwell 1965:13; originally published 1946)

This was Orwell's conclusion to a short and presumably partly comic essay on changes in the nature of murder in which he set the traditional English murder, one which 'can have dramatic and even tragic qualities which make it memorable and excite pity for both victim and murderer', against the newer 'Americanised' murder cited in which there is 'no depth of feeling'. He continues: 'it was almost by chance that the two people concerned committed that particular murder, and it was only by good luck that they did not commit several others.' According to Orwell, the two murderers were an English woman who had said 'she wanted to do something dangerous, "like being a gun-moll"', and an American army deserter who had, untruthfully, 'described himself as a big-time Chicago gangster'. Significantly, 'the background' to the murder 'was not domesticity, but the anonymous life of the dance halls and the false values of the American film' (ibid.: 11–12).

Orwell was equally critical of the moral cynicism of the 'Americanised' crime novel. The example he had in mind was *No Orchids For Miss Blandish*, which featured a gangster as its 'hero'. This he compared with the less morally ambivalent 'Raffles' books which were also about the activities of a

criminal hero figure. In contrasting these crime novels, the latter dating from the turn of the century, the former being published in 1939, Orwell was concerned with 'the immense difference in moral atmosphere between the two books, and the change in popular attitude that this probably implies' (ibid.: 63; the author of the 'Raffles' books was E.W.Hornung). In view of the Americanised and popular character of the *No Orchids* novel, Orwell argued that there were 'great numbers of English people who are partly Americanised in language and, one ought to add, in moral outlook'. He cites as evidence the fact that 'there was no popular protest against *No Orchids*', though 'the ordinary reader ought to have objected to—almost certainly would have objected to, a few decades earlier—...the equivocal attitude towards crime.' The novel implies 'that being a criminal is only reprehensible in the sense that it does not pay' and that therefore 'the distinction between crime and crime prevention practically disappears.' By contrast, 'even a book like *Raffles*...is governed by powerful taboos, and it is clearly understood that *Raffles*'s crimes must be expiated sooner or later.' But, 'in America, both in life and fiction, the tendency to tolerate crime, even to admire the criminal so long as he is successful, is very much more marked' (ibid.: 73).

If such Americanisation is indeed a trend then, for Orwell, 'there would be good grounds for dismay'. *Raffles* may have been a criminal but he was also a 'gentleman' and subscribed to a code of moral honour, even if this in the end turned out to be no more than 'the reflexes of a gentleman'. On the other hand, in books like *No Orchids*,

there are no gentlemen and no taboos. Emancipation is complete. Freud and Machiavelli have reached the outer suburbs. Comparing the schoolboy atmosphere of the one book with the cruelty and corruption of the other, one is driven to feel that snobbishness, like hypocrisy, is a check upon behaviour whose value from a social point of view has been underrated.

(ibid.: 79)

After all, according to Orwell, intellectuals, unlike the 'common people', had by then got used to reading 'serious novels' which no longer dealt in the 'world of absolute good and evil', and which no longer provided a clear division 'between right and wrong' (ibid.: 77–78).

For writers such as Orwell, Americanisation did not pose the threat to folk culture that it did for those critics of mass culture we discussed earlier. Rather, it threatened his notion of Englishness. However, it also posed a threat to his idea of the established working-class community which shared many of the qualities ascribed by mass culture critics to the rural folk community, even if it was a product, not of an agrarian society, but of an industrial and urban capitalism. These included organic harmony, shared authentic values, a moral sense of communal and individual worth, autonomous leisure pursuits, and genuine patterns of social integration.

The better known and more extensive presentation of this position is that put forward by the English cultural critic Richard Hoggart (b. 1918). Hebdige links Orwell and Hoggart together in what he calls a 'negative consensus' since they knew what they wanted to preserve—the traditional working-class community—rather than what they wanted to change. He argues that 'Orwell and Hoggart were interested in preserving the "texture" of working-class life against the bland allure of post-war affluence—television, high wages, and consumerism' (Hebdige 1988:51; cf. pp. 50–52).

In his justly famous book *The Uses of Literacy*, first published in 1957 (a book which has been central to the development of the study of popular culture in Britain) Hoggart tried to document how the traditional and closely knit working-class community was being taken over by what he called 'a shiny barbarism'. Writing about the background in which he grew up, he said his was not simply a critical attack upon mass culture and Americanisation, nor a statement of a particular set of preferences. He viewed what he was doing, in part, as

providing a sociology of the uses of popular culture, and of the role of media in people's lives. As Passeron has noted, Hoggart's book draws 'attention to the fact that the reception of a cultural message should not be dissociated from the social conditions in which it occurs and thus from the ethos which essentially characterises a social group' (cited in Dyer 1973:40).

The 'shiny barbarism' Hoggart feared was defined by mass culture and Americanisation. In particular, he was concerned about the manipulative and exploitative influence exercised over the working-class community, most especially over its more vulnerable younger members, by the America of the Hollywood film, the cheap and brutal crime novel, 'milk bars' and juke-box music. As Webster has pointed out (1988:187), Hoggart's view of the value and influence of American culture is not totally dismissive or negative. He recognises, for example, the vibrancy and relevance of the more realistic and straightforward qualities of the 'tough-guy' American crime novel in its appeal to working-class readers. However, there is little doubt that, in the end, Hoggart lumps together Americanisation and working-class youth in an elegantly argued moral warning about the debasement of working-class life and the gradual wearing down of the traditional working-class community. Hoggart saw the 'newer mass arts' such as 'sex-and-violence novels', 'the "spicy" magazines', 'commercial popular songs' and the 'juke-box' enticing working-class people to lose themselves and their culture in a mindless and trivial 'candy-floss world', the 'hollow brightness' of a 'shiny barbarism', a world brought to them from across the Atlantic.

Some of Hoggart's most extended condemnations of the impact of Americanisation are reserved for working-class youth. The 'juke-box boys', who frequented what were known in the 1950s and early 1960s as 'milk bars', get special attention:

the milk-bars indicate at once, in the nastiness of their modernistic knick-knacks, their glaring showiness, an aesthetic breakdown so complete that, in comparison with them, the layout of the living-rooms in some of the poor homes from which the customers come seems to speak of a tradition so balanced and civilized as an eighteenth-century town house ...most of the customers are boys aged between fifteen and twenty, with drape-suits, picture ties, and an American slouch. Most of them cannot afford a succession of milkshakes, and make cups of tea serve for an hour or two whilst —and this is their main reason for coming—they put copper after copper into the mechanical record-player... The young men waggle one shoulder or stare, as desperately as Humphrey Bogart, across the tubular chairs.

(Hoggart 1958:203–204)

Hoggart's view is clear: American mass culture leads the 'jukebox boys' away from the lived authenticity of their working-class backgrounds and into the empty fantasy world of Americanised pleasures.

During the period after the end of the Second World War in Britain, Americanisation had become an aspect of some more general fears and anxieties about the increasing capacity of the young and the working class to participate in the slowly emerging consumer society. Booker defined Americanisation, in his idiosyncratic social and cultural history of post-war Britain, as 'a brash, standardised mass-culture, centred on the enormously increased influence of television and advertising, a popular music more marked than ever by the hypnotic beat of jazz, and the new prominence, as a distinct social force, given to teenagers and the young' (Booker 1969:35). As Americanisation came to be associated with increased consumerism on the part of the young and the working class, America itself came to be an object of consumption. As Frith notes, 'the American dream became an inextricable part of mass cultural fantasies. In German film director Wim

Wenders's words, "The Americans colonised our sub-conscious" ... America, as experienced in film and music, has itself become the object of consumption, a symbol of pleasure' (1983:46).¹¹ Consequently, Hebdige can argue that invoking 'the spectre of Americanisation could be used to stand in for any combination of the following ideological themes: the rebellion of youth, the "feminisation" of British culture, the collapse of authority, the loss of Empire, the breakdown of the family, the growth in crime, the decline in attendance at places of worship, etc.' (1988:58).

These themes inform Hoggart's arguments, but he was just as interested in what was being lost in the process. For example, he associated Americanisation and the milk bar with the loss of the communal sociability of the working-class pub for they represented 'a sort of spiritual dry rot amid the odour of boiled milk'. He came to this conclusion because 'many of the customers—their clothes, their hair-styles, their facial expressions all indicate—are living to a large extent in a myth-world compounded of a few simple elements which they take to be those of American life' (Hoggart: 1958:204). There is thus in Hoggart's work the idea that the 'genuine' working-class community is in the process of being dissolved into cultural oblivion by mass culture and Americanisation (*ibid.*: 164–165 and 282–285).

Americanisation and the critique of mass culture theory

The criticisms that can be made of this particular understanding of Americanisation can be used to introduce a more general critique of mass culture theory. There are other ways of understanding the process of Americanisation in Britain, and we shall now look at some of these before proceeding to the general critical conclusions of this chapter.

Many nineteenth-century cultural critics were concerned about Americanisation because they identified it with mass democratic populism, and thus feared it would allow the masses to run the government and lower cultural standards.

Others, however, associated America with democracy, modernity, rationality and science. The scientist T.H.Huxley, for example, saw America as representing the promise of a scientific and rational future. Huxley was an optimist who saw little benefit in trying to preserve social and cultural forms which were in decline. Instead, he saw immense possibilities being opened up for everybody by the forward march of a progressive and scientific modernity. According to Johnson, 'Huxley was optimistic about the way in which society was developing, an attitude which he exhibited quite explicitly in his reaction to America'. When Huxley described 'his first sight of America, he remarked on the excitement he felt on seeing the towers and buildings of the post office and other communication centres, instead of the spires of churches'. This symbolised, for him, 'the Americans' interest in knowledge rather than superstition' (1979:50).

The example of a scientist like Huxley is instructive since his views illustrate an alternative understanding of America and Americanisation which can be used to offer a critical commentary on mass culture theory. In looking at this alternative we can begin with the reading public and the decline of literary standards stressed by Q.D.Leavis and Orwell. Other arguments indicate that the issues involved are more complex than a simple decline of standards. In his discussions with working-class people about their past lives, part of an attempt to construct an oral history, Worpole (1983) found that a surprising number of the people he talked to said that one type of reading matter they had preferred had been American crime and detective fiction. This led Worpole to the tentative speculation that, in the 1930s and 1940s, this fiction gave male, urban, working-class readers access to a language, a style and a subject matter that was more realistic, more relevant to their own lives, conditions and circumstances, more like the way they spoke and thought and dealt with other people, and which were not available in the literature written by and for the English upper and middle classes. As he writes:

it was in American fiction that many British working class readers...found a realism about city life, an acknowledgement of big business corruption, and an unpatronising portrayal of working class experience and speech which wasn't to be found in British popular fiction of the period, least of all in the crime novel obsessed as it was with the corpse in the library, the colonel's shares on the stock market, and thwarted passion on the Nile.

(Worpole 1983:35)

Among other things, this provides an interesting contrast to Orwell's complaints about the 'decline of the English murder' and the popularity of the American crime novel. It also perhaps opens up the difference between the critical arbitration of taste and a sociology of culture (cf. Bourdieu 1984:11-57).

Worpole's speculations are given support by White's historical study of a working-class street in north London, near Finsbury Park. This area, Campbell Bunk, had a reputation as one of the roughest and toughest in London, and White (1986) presents a historical overview of its development and eventual demise. With respect to the theme of Americanisation he remarks that 'the cinema forged...links between the male youth of Campbell Road and outside.' This applied particularly to 'American films' which 'offered heroes and heroines who were less hidebound by class than their technically inferior British counterparts.' For example, 'the glamourised male (especially young male) violence of films like *Little Caesar* (with Edward G. Robinson, 1930), *Public Enemy* (with James Cagney, 1931), *Scarface* (with George Raft, 1932), helped working-class youngsters see themselves as heroes rather than bystanders, the subject of life rather than its object.' As such, 'the adopted American accents, dress-styles and mannerisms, which many observers bemoaned as slavish emulation of a new trash culture, can be interpreted' as 'a self-conscious identification with a more democratic discourse

than anything British society (including its labour movement) had to offer them' (White 1986:166).¹²

The debate over the nature and effects of Americanisation in Britain can be traced back to the nineteenth century. But it seems to have become more significant and more contentious after 1945. In this context it is possible to contrast Hebdige's arguments with those put forward by Hoggart. For Hebdige, fears about Americanisation in the post-war period were linked to fears about the threat posed to traditional intellectual elites and their judgements about taste by the 'levelling-down process'. Ideas about America being more populist and democratic fed into concerns about increasing working-class affluence and consumption which threatened the intellectual arbitration of taste and middle-class consumption as forms of symbolic and positional power. Both Hebdige and Webster have argued that these fears reflected, to some degree, worries on the part of the 'British establishment' over the decline in Britain's world role and its increasing dependence upon the American state (Hebdige 1988: 58; Webster 1988:183–184 and the conclusion). But what Hebdige is at pains to question is whether the working class, and particularly young, white, working-class men living in the centres of large cities and involved in putting together their own sense of subcultural styles, could be described and understood in Hoggart's terms.

Hebdige's point is that Americanisation did not result in the greater cultural uniformity and homogeneity which the mass culture critics had predicted. On the contrary, he notes 'the sheer plethora of youth cultural options currently available... most of which are refracted through a "mythical America"' (1988: 74). This is so because, for him, 'American popular culture—Hollywood films, advertising images, packaging, clothes and music—offers a rich iconography, a set of symbols, objects and artefacts which can be assembled and re-assembled by different groups in a literally limitless number of combinations.' In this process, 'the meaning of each selection is transformed as individual objects—jeans, rock records,

Tony Curtis hair styles, bobby socks, etc.—are taken out of their original historical and cultural contexts and juxtaposed against signs from other sources' (ibid.; cf. Hebdige 1979).

According to Hebdige, young working-class males—his version of the 'juke-box boys'—do not consume their imaginary America in a passive and unreflective manner. They construct it with the popular cultural materials available, rather than being constructed by them. It does not matter that their America is 'imaginary' because that is the point—it possesses its 'magic' because it is 'imaginary'. They consume styles in images, clothes and music in an active, meaningful and imaginative fashion, one which transforms the meanings of Americanisation and converts them into distinct subcultural tastes. Hebdige suggests that these young, urban, working-class men have used the images, styles and vocabularies of American popular culture in their own distinctive and positive ways as a form of resistance, albeit not a radical one, to middle-class and upper-class culture, and as a spirited defence against their own subordination.

Moreover, this assimilation and transformation of a 'mythical America' has gone along with the adoption of European styles and fashions. For example, the 'mods', a young working-class subculture based in the central areas of large cities which emerged first in the early 1960s, borrowed as much from Italy (suits and scooters), as they did from black American popular culture (modern jazz and soul music). In fact, Hebdige quotes the anonymous working-class spy hero of Len Deighton's first novel, *The Ipcress File*, in this context. He notes that 'until the 1960s the romantic affirmation of American culture tended to be left to such unashamedly "popular" weeklies as *Titbits* and to the undergrowth of literature—the novelettes, comics and Hollywood ephemera—which were aimed at a predominantly working-class market'. However, 'by 1960, this market—at least significant sections of it, particularly amongst the young—had swung again — way from the exuberant vocabularies of streamlining and rock' (1988:74).

This change was marked for Hebdige by the appearance of Deighton's novel in 1962. The words of the novel's narrator and anti-hero early on in the book identify the character of the transition: 'I walked down Charlotte Street towards Soho... I bought two packets of Gauloises, sank a quick grappa with Mario and Franco at the Terrazza, bought a *Statesman*, some Normandy butter and garlic sausage' (Deighton 1978:22). 'What is so remarkable here', according to Hebdige, 'is the defection of a man like Harry Palmer not to Russia—still less to America—but to Italy...to the Continent.' He continues: 'it is perhaps the final irony that when it did occur the most startling and spectacular revolution in British "popular" taste in the early 1960s involved the domestication not of the brash and "vulgar" hinterland of American design but of the subtle "cool" Continental style which had for so many decades impressed the British champions of the modern movement' (1988:75). Harry Palmer 'is a fictional extension of mod' (ibid.).¹³ Moreover, 'the "spy masters", Burgess and Maclean (followed later by Philby)—motivated, or so the story goes, by a profound contempt and loathing for America, for American cultural, economic and military imperialism, for the "Americanization" of the globe, had flown the roost leaving men like Palmer to take care of things' (ibid.: 76).

The contrast between elitist and populist evaluations of Americanisation is made evident for Hebdige by the example of the spy novel, which he also uses to show how 'foreign' cultural influences, other than those deriving from America, were crucial to subcultures and to popular culture more generally. Indeed, if he had continued to trace out these differences in the spy novel, he would have noted that the motives which led the mole in John Le Carré's novel *Tinker, Tailor, Soldier, Spy*, to betray his country, arose from a deeply felt anti-Americanism. In his confession at the end of the novel, the mole, very much a Leavisite rather than a mod, cites Britain's global decline and irrelevance, and America's capitalist exploitation and materialism, as his reasons for his secret defection to the Soviet Union (Le Carré 1975:306).

However, it is not at all clear how much can be argued about wider social and cultural developments on the basis of a small number of conveniently selected novels. Also, novels may be used to write social history, but whether they are works of social history is another matter. It has equally to be noted that the spy novel may not be as representative as Hebdige suggests, in that it is a genre of popular fiction which has tended to be dominated by British writers. Furthermore, as Hebdige notes himself, the influence of the Continent was experienced by a subculture which took its music from black American culture. Thus, the argument Hebdige makes may not be as easy to substantiate as he appears to suggest.

None the less, Hebdige's argument provides an effective contrast to that offered by Hoggart, and the comparison highlights some of the interesting problems associated with the analysis of the Americanisation of popular culture. Hebdige also begins to outline some of the difficulties confronted by mass culture theory. The debate about Americanisation has continued on into the 1970s and 1980s and has focused, for example, upon the threats posed to national cultural identities by popular American television programmes. For example, in her study of the Americanising influence of US soaps such as *Dallas*, Ang (1989) has shown how audiences can interpret them with ideologies of mass culture or populism. The discussion of Americanisation has tried to provide a relevant and useful illustration of some of the issues and problems raised by mass culture theory and its approach to the analysis of popular culture. It now remains to extend some of the critical points made above into a more general critique of this perspective.

A critique of mass culture theory

Nowadays, it seems, few would openly and willingly subscribe to mass culture theory. Yet it is still popular with those, for example, who are committed to the defence of what they see as great literature and great art. And though it may not always be swallowed whole, some of its specific

arguments, such as those on the value of distinguishing between art and popular culture, or the claim that popular culture isn't as good as it used to be, are still widely shared. Some theorists of postmodernism, for example, lament the lowering of aesthetic standards which contemporary popular culture has achieved, echoing the fears expressed by mass culture critics about the threat posed by mass culture to folk and elite culture (Jameson 1984; Collins 1989: [chapter 1](#)). The idea of an audience manipulated and pacified by the ideological appeals of advertising and consumerism can be found in variants of Marxist, feminist and structuralist theory. Even those perspectives which pride themselves on 'taking popular culture seriously' sometimes seem too apologetic and self-conscious when they make this case.

The first line of criticism I want to look at claims that mass culture theory is elitist. This was a charge F.R. Leavis rejected because he thought 'the word "elitism" is a product of ignorance, prejudice and unintelligence...appealing as it does to jealousy and kindred impulses and motives.' He insists 'there must always be elites, and, mobilizing and directing the ignorance, prejudice and unintelligence' through the charge of elitism merely 'aims at destroying the only adequate control for "elites" there could be' (cited in Johnson 1979:98).

However, it can be argued that the term elitism is highly relevant to any critical assessment of mass culture theory. Elitism can refer to a set of unexamined values which give rise to opinionated judgements about popular culture. The first problem which this suggests concerns the privilege conferred upon those positions from which popular or mass culture can be understood and interpreted. An elitist position assumes that popular or mass culture can only be understood and interpreted properly from the vantage point of the aesthetics and 'taste' of cultural and intellectual elites, that is high culture or 'high' theory. This is a problem because the principles or values which underlie this position are either taken for granted or remain unexamined. Elite values and

aesthetics are assumed to be valid and authoritative and therefore capable of assessing other types of culture, without any questions being raised about these assumptions and their ability to pass cultural judgements. Mass culture theory can be criticised for being elitist because elitism rests upon a set of unexamined values which shape the perceptions of popular culture held by its exponents.

Elitism also fails to recognise that mass culture can be understood, interpreted and appreciated by other groups in distinct, 'non-elitist' social and aesthetic positions within societies. On what basis can it be argued that some groups' perception of popular culture is better or more valid than that of other groups? In the discussion of Americanisation, we saw how working-class evaluations of mass culture have, at times, been strikingly different from those made by mass culture critics. Elitist judgements fail to recognise interpretations of popular culture developed from alternative vantage points, and the value these alternatives possess. In part, this occurs because elitism usually lacks any kind of sociology. Its usual response to the problem is to minimise the importance of the mass consumers of popular culture because they do not share the aesthetic assumptions of the elite. Hence mass culture theory's view of the consumers of mass culture as passive, manipulable, and exploitable 'cultural dopes'.

Equally, elitism, like mass culture theory, tends to ignore the range and diversity of popular culture, and the tensions and contradictions within it. It usually sees mass culture as necessarily and inevitably homogeneous and standardised. We have seen how the critique of the Americanisation thesis argued that popular culture is not homogeneous or standardised but offers diversity and difference, especially when it is reinterpreted and re-evaluated outside its original context. This argument makes two points which need to be noted here. First, popular culture is diverse because it is open to different uses and interpretations by different groups in society. Second, popular culture itself has to be seen as a diverse and varied set of genres, texts, images and

representations which can be found across a range of different media. For example, representations of women in advertising differ from those in soap operas because the latter portray women in a greater variety of roles (cf. Collins 1989:10–11 on television). While mass culture does at times make use of standardised formats, this is not unique to it but can equally be found in elite culture.¹⁴ Moreover, it is perfectly possible to appreciate some forms of popular or mass culture without accepting it all. If popular culture is not homogeneous, it need not be consumed as a whole. It can be consumed selectively due to the influence of more specific social and cultural factors than mass culture theory seems capable of recognising.

To some extent, the consumption of popular culture by the general public has been a problem for intellectuals, political leaders, and moral and social reformers. These groups have often taken the view that ideally people should be occupied with something more enlightening and worthwhile than popular culture. Q.D. Leavis's work suggests, for example, that readers would be better off with a novel from the great tradition of English literature than a pulp fiction magazine, while MacDonald implies that audiences should confine themselves to the theatre or silent and avant-garde films rather than mainstream Hollywood cinema. There are at least three points to this argument. The first is that mass culture takes up time and energy which should be devoted to other more preferable, constructive and useful pursuits such as art, politics or resuscitating folk cultures. The second is that mass culture has positively harmful effects on its audiences, making them passive, enervated, vulnerable and thus open to manipulation and exploitation. The third point is that bad mass culture drives out good culture, both folk culture and art.

But how is it possible to determine what people should consume, what popular culture they should like and dislike?; and what enables some people to pass judgement on the tastes of others? Taste and style are socially and culturally determined. It is the power to decide upon the definitions of

taste and style which circulate within societies which is important, rather than the remote possibility of finding universal and objective reasons for validating aesthetic judgements. The power to determine popular culture and the standards of cultural taste is not restricted to the economic and political power exercised by the mass culture industries, though they are obviously crucial for any adequate explanation of the overall process. It also includes, even if only as a secondary phenomenon, those intellectuals, or producers of ideas and ideologies, with the power to attempt to set down guidelines for cultural discrimination, and the position from which to try to decide what people should like and dislike. As Ang has pointed out, the ideology of mass culture influences the evaluations audiences make of popular culture even if it gives them obvious pleasure (1989: [chapter 3](#)). The production of aesthetic value judgements, and hierarchies of cultural taste, together with the conflicts they give rise to, are therefore relevant to this argument.

One way to claim objectivity for the critique of mass culture is to speak on behalf of the people, and praise the authenticity of their culture while condemning the artificiality of mass culture. Mass culture, unlike a genuine and authentic popular or folk culture, cannot arise from, nor be relevant to, the lives and experiences of people. However the definitions used in this argument are questionable. What does 'authentic' mean, and how can we know that a culture is authentic? Is there such a thing as a 'pure' culture, rooted in authentic communal values, and untainted by outside influences and commercial considerations?

Popular music is an area in which the roots and authenticity of particular styles are important issues, and are used to champion the superiority of certain genres such as folk, blues or country over the artificial and superficial character of commercial and mainstream popular music. Yet the criteria of originality, roots, community and authenticity can be deployed as marketing strategies to appeal to particular segments of the music audience while presumably most

musicians have to make a living. Also, how do authenticity or inauthenticity affect the pleasures music can afford its audience? Is it not possible for popular music with a wide appeal to be 'good', 'quality' music? Is it really the case that only authentic music is 'good' music? Questioning the idea of authenticity shows just how difficult it is to define, and how it may derive from a particular set of cultural tastes and values, rather than from a considered analysis of popular music.

The idea of authenticity is linked to mass culture theory's view of the past which is often said to be idealised and romanticised, picturing a society and culture fated to be ruined by the rise of mass culture. This version of the past is vividly captured by F.R. Leavis, who argues that 'what we have lost is the organic community with the living culture it embodied'. In this society 'folk-songs, folk-dances, Cotswold cottages and handicraft products are signs and expressions of something more: an art of life, a way of living, ordered and patterned, involving social arts, codes of intercourse and a responsive adjustment, growing out of immemorial experience, to the natural environment and the rhythm of the year' (cited in Johnson 1979:96).

It may be the case that this view of the past is not fanciful but merely an attempt to show what has been lost, and the subsequent consequences of that loss. Yet it is difficult to resist the conclusion that an idealised 'golden age', in which an authentic folk culture and a truly great high culture knew their places in an ordered world, is an intrinsic part of mass culture theory. If this is so, we can argue that the theory overestimates the past and underestimates the present. What about the standards of education and literacy in the kinds of community evoked by Leavis? What about the qualities and pleasures of contemporary popular culture? Are not the continuing economic, political and cultural inequalities to be found in the past and the present to some extent bound up with the differences between folk, elite and mass culture? Equally, this idea of the past again brings out the elitism of the theory, for the idealised past is based upon a cultural

hierarchy dominated by the standards of the elite, to which the people are expected to defer.

This sense of a decline from a past when things were better is by no means unique to mass culture theory. Nonetheless, its version of the past remains unclear. At what precise period of time and in what specific places could the communities and cultures referred to be found apart from the Cotswolds? Were they in their heyday in an age of mass illiteracy? As with most 'golden ages', this past is difficult to pin down historically and geographically. Moreover, when did the decline begin? With the emergence of a commercial market for popular culture? With the rise of the modern mass media? With the spreading ownership of the radio, the dominance of Hollywood cinema, or the location of a television set in most people's homes? Or is it all the fault of America? Representations of the past may themselves be cultural constructs and tell us more about the present than the past. Notwithstanding this, the questions raised suggest that mass culture theory is unclear about its terms, lacks a sense of history, and harbours an unfounded nostalgia for a romanticised and imaginary past.

Two further points emerge out of this problem. The first is that mass culture theory lacks an adequate understanding of social and cultural change. It registers and criticises the appearance of mass culture but fails to explain it. In this sense, it limits itself in not fully understanding something it attacks. Inevitably, this limits both its explanatory and its critical power. It is not enough to say mass culture is a consequence of industrialisation because a more precise argument about the links between the two is needed for an adequate explanation to be sustained. Second, the theory seems to imply a resentment on the part of certain groups of intellectuals to the threats posed by mass culture and mass democracy (popular culture, education, literacy, etc.) to their roles as cultural educators and arbiters of taste. Within a well defined and traditional social hierarchy, the production and protection of cultural standards and the arbitration of taste are carried out by elite intellectuals. The judgements they make

apply both to those classes which share a position of power and privilege, and to those in subordinate positions who participate in their own popular culture, while respectfully deferring to elite culture. Mass culture threatens this hierarchy. Dominant classes engage in the commercial production of mass culture, disregarding the standards set by intellectuals, and the people have access to a popular culture beyond the bounds of the traditional hierarchy and the criteria of cultural taste and distinction it embodies. The symbolic power of intellectuals over the standards of taste which are applied to the consumption of cultural goods becomes more difficult to protect and sustain when people can consume a mass culture which does not depend on intellectuals for its appreciation and its definitions of pleasure.

The distinctions drawn by mass culture critics between mass and high culture are not as clear cut or as static as they claim. The boundaries drawn between popular culture and art, or between mass, high and folk culture, are being constantly blurred and changed. They are not necessarily given, or consistently objective and historically constant, but are often indistinct and historically variable. Mass culture theory tends to condemn mass culture as a whole. F.R. Leavis, for example, is said to have dismissed cinema as a serious cultural form, though MacDonald was prepared to count some examples of cinema, such as Eisenstein's films, as art. Some jazz is now appreciated as art, though in the first half of the last century it was condemned as mass culture by mass culture theory and the Frankfurt School. Alfred Hitchcock made commercial films within the Hollywood system but has since been defined as an auteur, an original and creative genius. Early rock-'n'-roll records, once dismissed as mindless pap by music critics, are now accorded 'classic' status by changing critical standards. It would be possible to go on, but what comes out of the examples cited is the difficulty of maintaining a clear divide between art and popular culture. This, in turn, suggests that analysing distinctions between types of culture should take account of the historically shifting

power relations between the groups involved, and the categories of taste at stake in the making of these distinctions (Levine 1988; DiMaggio 1986).

The evaluations developed of popular culture can embody different types of politics. In this sense, mass culture theory has the potential to draw anti-democratic conclusions. It would be unfair to suggest that all writers in this tradition are unrepentant elitist reactionaries. None the less, there is a tendency for the critical stance of mass culture theory to lament the emergence of mass democracies, and mass cultural markets, and to see an elite avant-garde as the only potential saviour of cultural standards. This tendency can be found in theories which claim to be democratic, but mass culture theory can seem to be anxious about the equalitarian effects of democracy which allow the masses rather than elites to determine what counts as culture.

A problem which needs to be dealt with in this critique concerns mass culture theory's inadequate understanding of the role of the audience in popular culture. In putting forward a feminist critique, Modleski (1986a; cf. [Chapter 5](#) below) has pointed out how mass culture theory tends to 'feminise' mass culture. It attributes to mass culture qualities which are culturally equated with the feminine, such as consumption, passivity and sentiment or emotion, and contrasts these with qualities such as production, activity and intellect, which are culturally equated with the masculine, and defined as art or high culture. The hierarchical relationship between art and mass culture is equivalent to, and reinforced by, the hierarchical relationship between masculinity and femininity. The power of men over women is reflected in the cultural distinction between art and mass culture. This means that one major reason for the critical dismissal of mass culture arises from its allegedly 'feminine' qualities. For example, mass culture, such as cinema or the soap opera, is denigrated because it is sentimental and plays on people's emotions. It can be dismissed because it evokes reactions associated with the feminine. Hence, one of the threats posed by mass culture,

according to its critics, is that it will feminise its audience. For example, the language used in some accounts of mass culture refers to its seductive power to conquer a passive and vulnerable audience through fantasies of romance and escape.

Another way of looking at this problem is to be found in Ang's analysis (1989) of the ideologies used by viewers to account for their reasons for watching and evaluating the American television soap *Dallas*. She found those who disliked or hated the series, and those who watched but laughed at it from a carefully cultivated and 'ironic distance', were confident and secure in the judgements they made and the grounds upon which they could make them. However, those who liked the series tended to be far less confident about expressing and rationalising their preference. Some dealt with this anxiety by bringing out what they saw as the serious qualities of the series, indicating, for example, how its message is that money cannot buy happiness. However, others seemed apologetic and diffident about deriving pleasure from such an obviously inferior, Americanised, mass cultural product.

Ang accounts for this contrast by suggesting that two distinct, discursive and publicly available ideologies are at work. Without necessarily succumbing to the evaluations these ideologies imply, she distinguishes between an ideology of mass culture and an ideology of populism.¹⁵ The first, which has things in common with the theory outlined in this chapter, is the one the first set of viewers resort to in accounting for their hostile and ironic response. This ideology of mass culture appears to be more prominent as a public discourse about cultural evaluations of what is good and bad. It underpins the confident critique of the series as yet another example of Americanised mass culture. From this point of view, *Dallas* serves as a resonant symbol of the Americanisation of Europe. By contrast, the ideology of populism, which tolerates, in an equalitarian way, different kinds of cultural taste and accepts that people know what they like, is used to account for the pleasures the viewers who liked

the series derived from watching it. It lay behind their response, though it was expressed with much less confidence and vigour than the ideology of mass culture. One implication of this analysis, apart from its study of how viewers can evaluate what they watch on television, is that it sees the relationships between audiences and popular culture not as mass culture theory does, but as an aspect of the shifting association between power and knowledge.

Mass culture theory generally tends to see the audience as a passive, vulnerable, manipulable, exploitable and sentimental mass. It is resistant to intellectual challenge and stimulation but easy prey to consumerism and advertising and the dreams and fantasies they have to sell. It has little awareness of good taste, and is devoted to the repetitive formulas of mass culture. A number of criticisms can be made of this idea of the audience. First, is there any such thing as a mass audience? Producers of popular culture may not need to reach a mass audience, but sections of a market divided and stratified by tastes, values and preferences as well as money and power. The need for producers to maximise their audiences is a specific instance of cultural production and consumption, and not a guaranteed outcome in societies where mass consumption prevails. The mass audience may not even exist at the point of consumption because the evaluations and effects of popular culture will vary in line with the social character of consumers. The conclusions reached by mass culture theory are difficult to substantiate without knowledge of the social positions occupied by consumers of popular culture in the wider society.

Second, can people's consumption of popular culture be characterised in the way mass culture theory suggests? Can the view that the audience for popular culture is an undifferentiated mass of passive consumers be sustained? To answer these questions adequately we need to see audiences as socially and culturally differentiated, and to recognise that cultural taste is socially constructed. We also need to acknowledge that audiences may be more knowing, active

and discriminating in their consumption of popular culture than has usually been conceded by popular culture theory. This theory has tended to speak on behalf of the audience rather than finding out what it has to say for itself. However, this point need not imply that audiences are somehow as powerful, if not more powerful, than the producers of popular culture.¹⁶ We shall return to this below when we consider cultural populism.

Further reading

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